Salisbury Water

In Adelaide, South Australia, an innovative water recycling system in use in the suburb of Salisbury has reduced extraction from the Murray River and aquifers by about a half. Wastewater from the local sewage treatment works and rainwater from drains are treated, and then directed into a series of 50 wetlands. These contain reedbeds and other aquatic vegetation that further clean the water. The recycled, non-drinking water from the wetlands is then piped to the inhabitants of Salisbury to use for flushing toilets, watering gardens, washing cars, and filling ornamental ponds.

In addition to providing a more sustainable source of water, the system has boosted biodiversity within the newly established wetlands. Among the birds that are currently resident or visitors are ducks, spoonbills, herons, pelicans, cormorants, and migratory waders, along with species of amphibians and fish, and many aquatic invertebrates.